

DAY 25: CUT HOLIDAY SPENDING

The holidays happen at the same time every year, yet we are still caught off guard when we realize Christmas is a little less than a week away. What is supposed to be the most joyous and peaceful season of the year quickly turns into one of stress as we realize all the cookies we need to bake, decorations to put up, gifts to buy (and wrap!), and how much money we have to spend along the way.

Although Joseph and I budget for these types of things, we don't always stay under it. We too get swept up in the advertisements, magazine-worthy gift guides, and enticingly low prices of gifts that weren't in our price range to begin with. The hustle and bustle of the crowds, stores, and ticking time clock don't help that much either.

Before we know it, we're rushing around buying everything we "need," so we can make this Christmas the one to remember. Meanwhile, we stop paying attention to how much it costs, because we just want to get it done as quickly as possible. But those receipts add up, my friend!

If this sounds all too familiar, then it's time to stop shopping without a plan and prep your finances so they don't take such a hit during the holiday season—because they don't have to. You can be smart with where and how much you spend, and still have a gorgeous celebration with money left over. Yep, it's true!

Here are six creative ways to cut costs, *and* create a stress-free holiday:

1. START SAVING NOW

Like I mentioned before, Christmas should not come as a surprise to anyone. It's the same day, in December, every year, and we have 364 days to prep for it—so let's use that time wisely!

I set money aside starting in January—a little from each paycheck—so by the time Christmas rolls around, I know exactly how much money I have to